drawing up of a list of cadres considered likely to come out. Then came the 'silent surrenders'—those who had already surrendered but not officially. They acted as key operatives, encouraging others to follow. The monsoon normally brings a lull in operations, with vast stretches of Bastar cut off by heavy rains. But not this year. Security forces pushed deep into forested Abujhmad, long seen as a Maoist safe haven. The pressure to surrender only grew.

Semantics matter in the surrender game. Naxals coming out of the fold dislike the word 'surrender'; they insist the agitation will continue, only without guns. So, a new term, 'Poona Margam', was coined—one they are more comfortable with. Local civil society workers, schoolteachers, panchayat office-bearers and even journalists are acting as a bridge between the state and the insurgents, trying to persuade them to lay down arms. The police, meanwhile, refuse to ease the pressure. "The first condition is lay down arms. We are not negotiating with the Maoists but offering a package for those who lay down arms and join the mainstream," says Sundarraj.

RACE TO THE DEADLINE

A week before Madvi Hidma, one of India's most-wanted Maoist commanders, was killed by the Andhra Pradesh Police on November 18, Chhattisgarh deputy CM and home minister Vijay Sharma visited Puvarti, Hidma's ancestral village, and had lunch with his mother and the mother of Barse Deva, now seen as the commander of Battalion No. 1. Hidma's mother issued an appeal urging the fugitives to surrender, but nothing came of it. His killing, coming soon after this Track Two diplomacy effort, prompted local leaders, including former CPI MLA Manish Kunjam, to suggest rifts within the Maoist leadership. Devji, the politburo member opposed to surrenders, may have had a role in tipping off the police, he feels. Top Maoist leaders, however, deny any schisms and insist those who wish to surrender are free to do so (*see interview*).

Even as large groups surrender, not everyone in their is willing to follow.



ANI

BREAKING THE RED HOLD

At the recent DGP-IGP conference in Raipur, PM Narendra Modi urged holistic development in LWE-freed regions as home minister Amit Shah projected a Naxal-free India by next year

- **The choice of Raipur—capital of the most Naxal-affected state, Chhattisgarh—as the conference venue was telling**
- **Prime Minister Modi's core message was a call for holistic development in regions being freed from Left Wing Extremism (LWE)**
- **His remarks signalled that while major gains have been made against LWE, the next phase of the campaign will centre on development**
- **Home minister Shah reiterated his claim that Naxalism would be wiped out by next year, saying it would end before the next DGP/IGP conference**
- **Shah said 586 fortified police stations have been built and Naxal-affected districts have reduced significantly since 2014**
- **He noted that for 40 years, three problems—Naxalism, insurgency in the Northeast and Kashmir—had festered and the Modi regime has found lasting solutions to all of them**
- **Shah said the key to tackling radicalisation, extremism and narcotics lies in accuracy of intelligence, clarity of objectives and synergy in action**

EVEN AS LARGE GROUPS SURRENDER, NOT EVERYONE IN THE NAXAL LEADERSHIP IS WILLING TO FOLLOW. SOME REMAIN DETERMINED TO FIGHT

Some remain determined to fight, whatever the consequences. "What Kunjam is suggesting—that Devji did Hidma in—is not true. Devji does not want to surrender even when he knows what the consequences are. Hidma had the same view," Rupesh tells INDIA TODAY. Meanwhile, Sharma has rejected the appeal by Anant, spokesperson of the Maoists' Maharashtra-Madhya Pradesh-Chhattisgarh Zone, urging the three CMs to suspend offensive operations till February 16 to facilitate surrenders. Sharma said the date was too distant and that surrenders could be organised sooner. Anant has now sought time till January 1. In a social media message, he said he is unsure whether Ramder, the zone's top operative, is ready to surrender, but said his group will break away and do so if Chhattisgarh gives the go-ahead. There are others, like senior Maoist leader Papa Rao, who appear unwilling to surrender.

With less than four months to go for the March 31, 2026, deadline, both sides will have to take tough decisions. On that will depend whether India will truly be Naxal-free in the coming year or not. ■